

Scottie Barnes: Two-Way Engine + DPOY Case (2025–26)

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Executive Summary

Scottie Barnes has long stood out for his rare blend of size, vision, and defensive versatility. While his scoring remains solid rather than dominant, his all-around skillset has always pointed toward elite two-way impact. This season, with Brandon Ingram being brought in to absorb offensive responsibility, Barnes has been able to shift more of his energy toward defense. The result has been a defining stretch where his activity, versatility, and disruption have powered the Raptor's rise into a top-five defensive unit.

Offense

Passing is the engine

Table 1: Counting stats by season - 2025–26 (career highs highlighted)

season	g	fg	fga	fg percent	x3p	x3pa	x3p percent	x2p	x2pa	x2p percent	e fg percent	ft	fta	ft percent	orb	drb	trb	ast	stl	blk	tov	pf	pts
2021-22	74	6.2	12.6	0.492	0.8	2.6	0.301	5.4	10.0	0.543	0.524	2.1	2.9	0.735	2.6	4.9	7.5	3.5	1.1	0.7	1.8	2.6	15.3
2022-23	77	6.0	13.2	0.456	0.8	2.9	0.281	5.2	10.3	0.505	0.487	2.5	3.2	0.772	2.3	4.3	6.6	4.8	1.1	0.8	2.0	2.2	15.3
2023-24	60	7.5	15.7	0.475	1.7	4.9	0.341	5.8	10.8	0.536	0.528	3.3	4.2	0.781	2.4	5.9	8.2	6.1	1.3	1.5	2.8	2.0	19.9
2024-25	65	7.3	16.4	0.446	1.2	4.3	0.271	6.1	12.0	0.508	0.482	3.5	4.6	0.755	1.7	6.0	7.7	5.8	1.4	1.0	2.8	1.7	19.3
2025-26	54	7.5	14.9	0.504	0.9	3.0	0.301	6.6	11.9	0.555	0.534	3.4	4.1	0.820	2.2	6.2	8.4	5.6	1.3	1.6	2.6	2.9	19.3

This season, Barnes has taken meaningful steps forward as an efficient scorer. He is posting career highs in FT%, 2P%, and eFG%, reflecting improved touch and shot selection alongside a primary option in Brandon Ingram. His passing is what separates him offensively. Averaging 5.6 assists per game, Barnes functions as a primary facilitator, using his size and length to see over defenses and access passing windows most players simply cannot.

Playtypes and where his size creates advantages

Table 2: Barnes most efficient playtypes (2025–26)

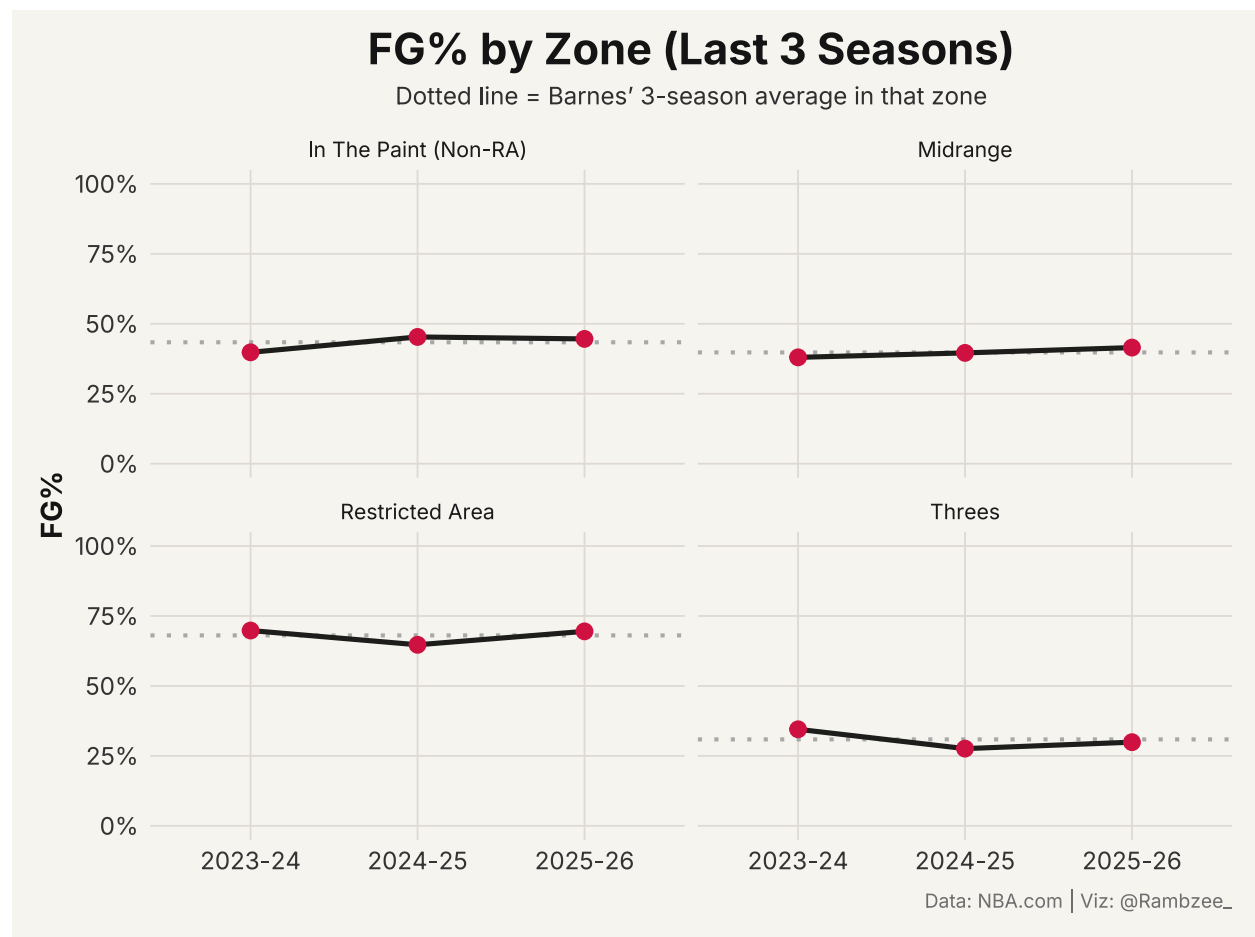
playtype	possessions	percent time	ppp	ppp rating	fga	fg percent	e fg percent	to percent	x2fga	x2fg percent	x3fga	x3fga percent
Transition	249	0.232	1.157	Good	174	0.644	0.675	0.189	147	0.687	27	0.407
P&R Ballhandler	135	0.126	0.874	Good	99	0.465	0.480	0.178	89	0.483	10	0.300
Isolation	84	0.078	1.000	Very Good	58	0.500	0.509	0.095	51	0.549	7	0.143
P&R Rollman	56	0.052	1.339	Very Good	46	0.652	0.663	0.054	42	0.690	4	0.250

Scoring has never been Barnes' calling card, but he has shown he can reliably function as a secondary option. He is comfortable operating in pick-and-roll on either side of the action, using his size to see over defenses as a ballhandler and his strength and touch to convert as a roll man. He can create his own shot when needed, and transition remains one of his clearest strengths, where his length and coordination allow him to cover ground and make quick, decisive reads. Even in lower-volume roll man opportunities, he has been highly effective, finishing through contact or leveraging his passing ability to punish help when defenses collapse.

Scoring context and shot zones

Table 3: Scottie Barnes shot zones (last 3 seasons)

player	zone	season	fgm	fga	fg percent
Scottie Barnes	Restricted Area	2025-26	205	295	69.5
Scottie Barnes	In The Paint (Non-RA)	2025-26	103	231	44.6
Scottie Barnes	Midrange	2025-26	54	130	41.5
Scottie Barnes	Threes	2025-26	49	164	29.9
Scottie Barnes	Restricted Area	2024-25	183	283	64.7
Scottie Barnes	In The Paint (Non-RA)	2024-25	135	298	45.3
Scottie Barnes	Midrange	2024-25	80	202	39.6
Scottie Barnes	Threes	2024-25	76	275	27.6
Scottie Barnes	Restricted Area	2023-24	210	301	69.8
Scottie Barnes	In The Paint (Non-RA)	2023-24	94	236	39.8
Scottie Barnes	Midrange	2023-24	41	108	38.0
Scottie Barnes	Threes	2023-24	102	296	34.5



Though he is not among the league's elite in finishing or touch shots, Barnes is comfortably above average in both, which makes him a legitimate scoring threat whenever he gets into the paint. As his range extends, however, his efficiency drops off. He has hovered around 40% from midrange and roughly 30% from three over the past three seasons, where his shot remains inconsistent. His jumper may never be a true strength,

but it isn't such a weakness that defenses can ignore him entirely or that it entirely drags down Toronto's offense.

Defense

Event creation: stocks + deflections

Table 4: Stocks per game leaderboard

rank	name	spg	bpg	bpg	spg	season	tm	gp	mpg
1	Victor Wembanyama	3.7	2.7	1.0	2025-26	SAS	41	28.9	
2	Scottie Barnes	2.9	1.6	1.3	2025-26	TOR	55	34.4	
3	Alex Sarr	2.8	2.0	0.8	2025-26	WAS	41	28.2	
4	Evan Mobley	2.8	1.9	0.9	2025-26	CLE	43	33.0	
5	Ausar Thompson	2.7	0.8	1.9	2025-26	DET	50	25.8	
6	Tyrese Maxey	2.7	0.8	1.9	2025-26	PHI	53	38.6	
7	Jalen Suggs	2.7	0.8	1.9	2025-26	ORL	34	26.5	
8	Derrick White	2.7	1.5	1.2	2025-26	BOS	53	34.3	
9	Kawhi Leonard	2.5	0.5	2.0	2025-26	LAC	42	32.8	
10	Jaren Jackson Jr.	2.5	1.4	1.1	2025-26	UTA	48	30.3	

Table 5: Deflections per game leaderboard

rank	player	gp	deflections
1	Kelly Oubre Jr.	33	4.3
1	Ausar Thompson	50	4.3
1	Cason Wallace	53	4.3
2	Dyson Daniels	54	4.2
3	Ryan Rollins	51	4.1
4	Kris Dunn	55	3.7
5	Jordan Goodwin	53	3.6
5	Kawhi Leonard	42	3.6
5	Tyrese Maxey	53	3.6
6	Jalen Suggs	34	3.5
6	VJ Edgecombe	51	3.5
6	Reed Sheppard	54	3.5
7	Herb Jones	33	3.4
7	Bilal Coulibaliy	34	3.4
7	Nickeil Alexander-Walker	55	3.4
8	Jake LaRavia	54	3.2
8	Scottie Barnes	55	3.2
8	Donte DiVincenzo	56	3.2
9	Dru Smith	54	3.1
9	Anthony Black	54	3.1

Defensive event creation is Barnes' superpower. His length and anticipation let him blow up possessions in ways few players can, jumping passing lanes, stripping ball handlers, and rotating over as a legitimate weak-side rim protector.

He ranks second in the league in stocks per game (2.9), trailing only Wembanyama, and is tied for eighth in deflections. That constant activity forces mistakes and creates extra possessions, which has been central to Toronto’s defensive identity this season.

On-ball defense: matchup workload + results

Table 6: Barnes defensive playtypes - workload + efficiency allowed

playtype	possessions	percent time	ppp allowed	rating	fga allowed	fg pct allowed	efg pct allowed	to pct forced
P&R Ballhandler	273	0.362	0.810	Very Good	200	0.380	0.445	0.172
Isolation	60	0.080	0.717	Excellent	46	0.391	0.402	0.183

On-ball, Barnes has been one of the most effective defenders in the league while carrying one of the heaviest workloads. He defends isolation and pick-and-roll ball-handler actions on roughly 45% of his total defensive possessions, regularly taking the toughest assignment and guarding the opposing team’s primary creator. Despite that volume and difficulty, he allows under 0.8 points per possession in both playtypes and forces turnovers on over 17% of those possessions, an elite combination of efficiency and disruption. Overall, opponents are shooting just 38.2% when Barnes is the primary on-ball defender this season, one of the lowest marks among high-volume perimeter stoppers. He grades in the 78th and 83rd percentiles while consistently ending plays himself, stripping ball handlers, blowing up actions early, and turning stops into transition chances where he’s most effective offensively.

Rim Protection & Rebounding

Rim protection is not his primary role, but Barnes holds up well as a weakside helper. He allows about 61.6% at the rim, just 1.6% worse than expected, while contesting over six shots per game. Among defenders handling that level of volume, he ranks 28th, a strong mark for someone whose main job is on the perimeter. He also finishes possessions consistently, grabbing 6.3 defensive rebounds per game, 21st in the league, preventing second chances and completing defensive stops.

Team impact: fueling a top-five defense

Table 7: Team DRTG leaderboard

rank	team	drtg
1	OKC	106.3
2	DET	108.4
3	SAN	110.7
4	MIA	111.6
5	HOU	111.9
5	TOR	111.9

All of his activity (the versatility, disruption, and defensive rebounding) translates directly to team impact. Barnes has been the backbone of a top-five Raptors defense, establishing the possession-to-possession consistency that’s fueled their 33–23 record. That defensive reliability gives Toronto a clear foundation and raises their margin for error on a nightly basis. With Wembanyama’s eligibility still uncertain, Barnes’ body of work this season has positioned him as one of the most deserving and credible DPOY candidates in the league.

Conclusion

- Barnes' offensive value starts with his passing and feel. He creates advantages and keeps the offense flowing without needing to force shots.
- His scoring is most effective in advantage situations, where his size lets him finish, draw help, or create easy looks for others.
- Defense is where he separates. His length, activity, and instincts consistently disrupt actions and end possessions.
- Toronto's top-five defense is anchored by his versatility, on-ball workload, and defensive rebounding.